

Assembly to provide for succession to movable and immovable properties to female members together with male members of the family.

Education: As part of its development plan, the government has mapped out a long term strategy to accomplish 100 per cent literacy. This, in turn will help eliminate poverty and empower the youth to ensure a financially stable and healthy state. Various schemes have also been implemented to ensure education for all.

The State government has made education free up to the college level. The government distributes free books, exercise books, school uniforms, raincoats, school bags, shoes and socks in all schools. The State government spends 17 per cent of its budget expenditure on education. Students up to the primary level receive uniforms and textbooks free of cost. Students of monastic schools and Sanskrit pathshalas are being provided with free uniforms and textbooks up to the primary level. Financial assistance is being provided to BPL [below poverty line] students up to the college level apart from the regular stipends and scholarships.

By any subjective or objective assessment, the achievements Sikkim has recorded in Education and Health sectors are noteworthy. Compared to the past, Sikkim has now hosts of Degree Colleges, Medical and Engineering Colleges, Sanskrit Mahavidyalaya, Computers and Communication Institutes and other educational centres spread across the State. One OBC residential school is being established at Kamrang and a Tribal Residential School is set up at Soyam in North Sikkim. One Boarding School shall be established for the SC students at Namchi.

Health care: Mr Chamling received the 4th JRD Tata Memorial award for Sikkim for its remarkable performance in the health sector. The state bagged this award for its achievements on such key indicators as literacy rate, child-sex ratio, full immunization, safe delivery, Plan expenditure on social sector, percentage of women married below the age of 18, total fertility rate, infant mortality rate, female youth literacy rate, school attendance rate for girls and safe child delivery.

The State government provides free health care facilities to all people in the State. Besides creating a strict legal framework for controlling the misuse of drugs, Sikkim has also earned accolades for prohibiting the sale of products like *gutka* and *paan masala*.

Power: Sikkim blessed with tremendous hydroelectric potential, to the tune of 8,000 MW, plans to generate 5,000 MW of electricity by the end of 2012. The completion of chain of hydro power projects in the Teesta basin alone will see Sikkim with surplus power and in a position to sell electricity to other neighbouring States.

Total Financial Inclusion: The State government has initiated preliminary steps to achieve total financial inclusion in Sikkim where each household will have bank access at its doorsteps with health insurance cover and also ensure efficient and timely delivery mechanism of social benefit schemes.

As per sources, the State government is set to seek proposals from potential firms for the proposed 'Sikkim Universal Financial Inclusion Project' where about 70,000 to 1 lakh households have been targeted to come under formal banking services network.

Sanitation: Awarded the prestigious first Nirmal Gram Purashkar to the Chief Minister for recording 100 percent sanitation coverage in Sikkim.

Democratic Decentralization:

The concept of democratic decentralization based on devolution of administrative and financial power to the grass root institutions has taken a firm root in Sikkim. As provided under the 73rd Amendment Act of the Indian Constitution, Sikkim has made an impressive headway in empowering our people in the working of Panchayati Raj Institution at the grass root level and granting power to where it actually belongs.

Welfare of Government Employees

The State Government has undertaken all possible welfare measures for the welfare of government employees in Sikkim. They occupy an enviable position earning highest salary and other perks at all levels in the Country. The pay scales of all employees have been raised by more than 300 percent. The group C and D employees and School Teachers are the best paid employees.

Reservation: The SDF government has provided seat reservation for Scheduled Castes and Scheduled Tribes in higher education, government and non-government jobs, panchayats and so on.

In Sikkim, even people of higher castes like Brahmins, Chhetris, Newars and Sanyasis have been accorded the status of Other Backward Castes (OBC). Sikkim is first State to provide reservation in education for the business community.

Affirmative share to womenfolk:

- First woman Speaker of the State Assembly
- First woman member in State Cabinet
- First woman Zilla Adhakshyas, Upa-adhakshyas,
- Chairperson, Sikkim State Commission for Women
- Chairperson, Sikkim Public Service Commission
- Secretaries in the State Administration
- Scores of welfare schemes introduced like Indira Mahila Yojana, Balika Samridhi Yojana, Prerna Yojana, Small Family Scheme, Widow Remarriage Scheme and Pension to widows of Ex-servicemen.
- 40 % reservation to women under PRI
- 30 per cent reservation in Government employment including Police
- Mother's name made mandatory in all official documents
- Inheritance rights to female member of family at par with male member in parental properties through a landmark legislation on June 10, 2008